Where Does Mom Stand Today?

A dated worksheet for what you know, what you're assuming and what's missing.

“She probably has too much” is an assumption. “The house is in her name and her pension comes on the first” is something you can write down.

Fill this in over a few visits, with Mom where she's willing. Beside each line, write how you know it: “seen on paper,” “Mom told me” or “guessing.” If you don't know, write “don't know” and leave it.

Rough is fine. Leave account numbers off, and don't add anything up.

Where she lives, and how she's managing

The state she lives in and roughly how long she has been there, whether she is married, and what she does on her own today. If anyone already helps with anything, say who and how often. Only what someone has seen.

FOR EXAMPLE Same house, same state, for as long as any of us can remember. Widowed. Drives, cooks and pays her own bills (seen). Denise takes her to the eye doctor and does the yard.

What comes in, and what she has

Each source of income, each account, her home and any other property, and any life insurance or annuity. One line each, with how you know it.

FOR EXAMPLE Social Security and a pension from the school district, both into her checking account (seen on a statement). The house is in her name alone, as far as we know (Mom told me; haven't seen the deed). A life insurance policy from years ago (guessing).

What we're assuming

What you or your relatives believe about Medicaid and about Mom's situation, and where each idea came from. Don't correct anything here. Just write it.

FOR EXAMPLE "She has too much to ever qualify." David heard it from a coworker. Nobody has checked it against Mom's state or her situation.

What's missing

Papers you looked for and didn't find, and every line above marked "guessing" or "don't know."

FOR EXAMPLE Haven't seen the deed. Don't know whether the life insurance policy is still in force. Mom will look in the safe-deposit box the next time she's at the bank.

What would make us look again

The changes that would bring you back to this page: in her health or care needs, her finances or her marital status. The rest of the time you can leave it alone.

FOR EXAMPLE If Mom starts needing a hand most days. If she sells the house or moves nearer to Denise.

Today's date, and who filled this in

What this shows you

Three things: what you know about where Mom stands and how you know it, what your family is assuming, and which papers are missing. It doesn't show whether she would qualify for anything. Nothing here adds up to a total, a score or a level, and nothing is compared with a limit. Rules vary by state, and what this picture means under them is a question for your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've put a date on what you know and marked what you're only assuming. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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